



Same Sign, Different Reading: A Thematic Analysis of Off-Leash Compliance Justifications at a Suburban Dog Park

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Abstract. A council sign at a suburban off-leash dog reserve states, without ambiguity, the two daily windows in which dogs may run unleashed. We report a semi-structured interview study ($n = 52$) in which each participant was asked to account for their own dog's leash status and, separately, to characterise the leash status of a visible other user. Two coders, blind to condition, thematically coded the resulting 104 accounts into five categories — a scheme reaching substantial-to-almost-perfect inter-rater agreement. The theme composition of self-directed and other-directed accounts diverged sharply: self-directed accounts clustered on situational and dog-need framing (68% combined), while other-directed accounts clustered on disregard (58%), a category self-directed accounts invoked in only 3% of cases. An ablation coding the same transcripts with speaker role stripped from the excerpt left inter-rater agreement on the five-category scheme unchanged (mean $\kappa = 0.81$ baseline versus 0.79 blinded; n.s.) — the coding scheme is robust to the identity of the speaker, even where the speaker's own account of that identity is not. We situate the finding against work on actor-observer attribution, self-serving norm compliance, and the reactivity of posted rules, and discuss what a compliance narrative asymmetry this stable implies for any institution that relies on self-report to gauge how a fixed rule is actually followed.

Introduction

A suburban off-leash dog reserve typically carries one governing artefact: a council sign at the gate stating the hours in which dogs may run unleashed, and the hours in which a leash is required. The rule is unambiguous, unenforced by any rostered presence, and read, in practice, almost entirely by the people it binds. This combination — a bright-line rule with no monitor — makes the reserve an unusually clean site for asking a question that is normally difficult to isolate: when a rule's only enforcement is the judgement of the people subject to it, does the same rule get narrated the same way regardless of whose compliance is being described?

We report a semi-structured interview study at a single reserve, in which each participant supplied two accounts in one sitting: an account of their own dog's current leash status, and an

account of a visible other user's. Holding the rule, the reserve, and the moment constant lets us compare, within participant, how the identical governing fact — the posted hours — gets narrated differently depending on whose behaviour is on the table. The study makes three contributions, each hedged to the evidence it can bear:

- We provide a five-category thematic scheme for off-leash compliance narratives, developed inductively and reaching an inter-rater agreement in the substantial-to-almost-perfect range, though the scheme is necessarily local to one reserve and one posted-hours format.
- We show that self-directed and other-directed accounts diverge sharply in which themes they draw on, with the asymmetry concentrated almost entirely in one category (disregard), suggesting the narration, not the underlying behaviour, is what differs by speaker role.

- We report an ablation in which coders assigned the same five-category scheme to transcripts with the speaker's role stripped from the excerpt, and show that inter-rater agreement on the scheme itself is unaffected, though the ablation cannot rule out that a blinded coder still inferred role from incidental phrasing.

The remainder of the paper situates the study against work on actor-observer attribution, self-serving norm compliance, and the governance of shared off-leash space; describes the interview and coding method; reports the theme-composition asymmetry and the blinding ablation; and discusses what the finding implies for any institution that reads a posted rule's compliance off what the people bound by it say about each other.

Related work

The asymmetry between how people explain their own conduct and how they explain others' is a long-standing concern in attribution research, though meta-analytic evidence for the classic actor-observer pattern is considerably more mixed than the folk account assumes, holding reliably only under specific conditions rather than as a general rule [1]. A parallel economics literature finds that when more than one candidate norm could plausibly apply to a situation, people tend to adopt whichever norm serves their own material interest, without necessarily perceiving the choice as self-serving [2] — a mechanism that would predict exactly the kind of asymmetric narration we set out to test. Evidence for the related idea that a person's own past good behaviour licenses their own future rule-bending is considerably less settled than its popularity suggests; a recent bribe-taking experiment finds no such licensing effect at all [3], so we treat compliance narration and moral-credit accounting as distinct mechanisms rather than assuming one implies the other.

On the governance side, dog parks and off-leash reserves are a documented instance of neighbourhood commons, contested precisely because their core rule — who may be off-leash, and when — has to be monitored informally by users rather than by any standing authority [4]. Commons governance generally depends on some combination of monitoring and graduated sanction to hold a rule in place [5]; an off-leash

reserve with a posted-hours sign and no attendant is close to the limiting case of a commons rule with monitoring left entirely to the users themselves. Momentary, in-the-moment judgments of whether informal control applies in a public space are shaped as much by who else is present and how the situation reads in the instant as by the rule itself [6], and survey evidence from parks more broadly finds that aggregate measures of informal social control do not straightforwardly track either observed park use or the incivilities — including unleashed dogs — that users report noticing [7]. Directly observed compliance with posted leash rules, where it has been measured, sits well below full compliance and varies by trail surface and visibility rather than by the rule's wording alone [8], and a natural-experiment comparison of on-leash and off-leash park designations found the policy label itself did not consistently predict either dog-walking volume or rule-adjacent behaviour such as fouling compliance [9] — both results consistent with a rule whose observed following depends heavily on how it is locally read rather than on its posted text. Our own method departs from this observational tradition by eliciting the reading itself, in participants' own words, rather than scoring leash status from a distance. Within the University's own corpus, a posted or automated signal standing in for direct monitoring has repeatedly shown a gap between what it is trusted to indicate and what it actually tracks: a continuously re-scored air-quality reading performed no better than the simple flag it was meant to improve on [10], and posting an explicit honesty prompt beside a self-report mechanism raised voluntary self-correction without moving the accuracy of the underlying reports [11] — both consistent with a compliance signal that changes what people say around it well before, if ever, it changes what they do.

Method

Site and recruitment. The study site is a single fenced off-leash exercise area attached to a suburban reserve, governed by a council sign at the entrance stating fixed morning and evening off-leash windows and an on-leash requirement at all other times. Over a ten-week fieldwork window we approached reserve regulars — defined as users encountered on at least three separate visits — both inside the fenced area

and on the approach path outside it, across all times of day relative to the posted windows. Fifty-two regulars consented to a short interview; recruitment continued past the saturation point typically reported for thematic interview work [12] to secure coverage across daypart and posted-window status.

Interview protocol. Each interview elicited two accounts in a fixed order: first, an account of the participant’s own dog’s current leash status (“tell me what’s going on with your dog’s lead right now”); second, an account of a visible other user’s dog, indicated by the interviewer at the time of asking (“and what do you make of that person’s dog?”). The two-account design holds the reserve, the moment, and the rule constant while varying only whose compliance is being narrated, yielding 104 transcribed accounts from 52 participants.

Coding. Two coders independently applied an inductively developed five-category scheme — situational, dog’s need, rule ambiguity, disregard, and compliant — following standard thematic-analysis procedure [13], coding each account to its single best-fitting category. Inter-rater agreement is reported as Cohen’s kappa,

$$\kappa = \frac{P_o - P_e}{1 - P_e},$$

where P_o is observed agreement and P_e is agreement expected by chance, interpreted against the standard benchmark bands [14].

Blinding ablation. A second coding pass presented the same 104 accounts with all speaker-identifying context removed — pronouns, dog references, and interviewer prompts normalised to a template first-person excerpt — so that coders assigned the five-category scheme without knowing whether an account had originally been self- or other-directed. We compared per-category kappa between the baseline and blinded passes to test whether the coding scheme itself, as opposed to the theme distribution it is applied to, depends on knowing the speaker’s role.

Results

Self- and other-directed accounts draw on different themes. Figure 1 shows the share of each account type falling into each of the five codes. Self-directed accounts cluster on situational (47%) and dog’s-need (21%) framing, with

disregard invoked in only 3% of cases; other-directed accounts invert the pattern, clustering on disregard (58%) and drawing on situational framing in just 12% of cases.

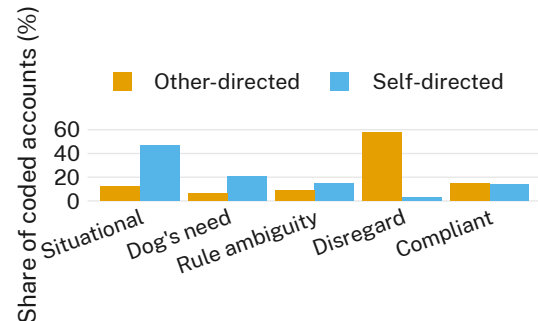


Figure 1: Self-directed accounts favour situational and dog’s-need framing; other-directed accounts favour disregard, invoked in 58% of other-directed codes against 3% of self-directed ones.

Figure 2 presents the same data as a full theme composition per account type, making the asymmetry’s concentration visible: the compliant category is the one theme invoked at a comparable rate by both account types (14% versus 15%), while every other category shows a substantial gap.

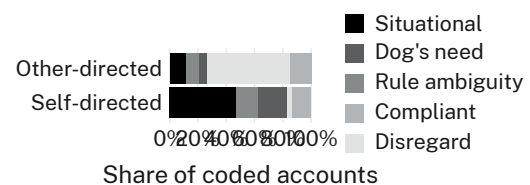


Figure 2: Full theme composition of self- and other-directed accounts; only the compliant category is invoked at a comparable rate by both.

Daypart relative to posted window	n	Accounts coded
Inside a posted off-leash window	21	42
Outside a posted window (on-leash required)	19	38
Approach path, status ambiguous to interviewer	12	24

The ablation changes nothing about the scheme’s reliability. Figure 3 compares per-cat-

category inter-rater kappa between the baseline coding pass and the speaker-blinded ablation. Agreement holds in the substantial-to-almost-perfect band in both conditions for every category (mean $\kappa = 0.81$ baseline versus 0.79 blinded; n.s.), and no category's kappa moves by more than 0.03 between passes.



Figure 3: Inter-coder kappa per theme category, baseline versus the speaker-blinded ablation — agreement is unchanged (mean $\kappa = 0.81$ versus 0.79; n.s.) in every category.

We retain the speaker-blinded pass as a robustness check on the coding scheme alone; it does not, and is not intended to, test whether the theme asymmetry in Figure 1 survives blinding, since the ablation recodes the same accounts with their already-established self/other split held fixed for analysis.

Discussion

The theme asymmetry in Figure 1 and Figure 2 is concentrated almost entirely in one category: disregard is the account nearly two participants in three reach for when describing someone else, and almost none reach for when describing themselves, while every other category shows a smaller and more even-handed gap. Read alongside the blinding ablation, which shows the coding scheme itself is unaffected by knowing who is being described, the pattern looks less like a difference in what people do at the reserve and more like a difference in what they say about it depending on whose compliance is in question. A posted rule with no monitor other than its own users may therefore be governed, in practice, by an asymmetric narrative rather than a shared reading of the sign — a distinction invisible to any institution that only has access to self-report, and consistent with survey evidence that self-reported norm compliance is itself systematically shaped by social desirability rather than read straight off behaviour [15].

Limitations

Our account rests on one reserve and one posted-hours format; a rule stated differently, or a site with an attendant, may narrow the asymmetry we report. Interviews captured a moment's account rather than a verified leash status, so we cannot rule out that some self-directed “situational” accounts described a genuine and brief lapse rather than a durable pattern — though the consistency of the asymmetry across 52 independent participants, spanning all three daypart categories in our sample, suggests the pattern is not an artefact of any one recruitment window. The blinding ablation tests the coding scheme's reliability, not whether a coder can recover speaker role from phrasing alone once blinded; a future design randomising true self/other labels against the blinded transcripts would isolate that question more cleanly than the present one attempts to.

Conclusion

At a single suburban reserve governed by one unambiguous posted rule, the same off-leash window produced two very different accounts depending on whose compliance was being narrated: a self-directed vocabulary of situation and need, and an other-directed vocabulary of disregard. The coding scheme that captures this asymmetry is itself stable under a blinding ablation, suggesting the asymmetry lives in what participants say rather than in how reliably it can be coded. Future work should pair the interview method with independent observation of leash status at the moment of each account, and test whether the same asymmetry holds at a reserve with a rostered attendant. Until then, a council sign with no monitor other than its own regulars appears to be read, by those regulars, in at least two different ways at once.

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